> And whereas it is expedient that the said Territories should be governed by and in the Name of Her Majesty: *Be it therefore enacted by the Queen's most Excellent Majesty, by and with the Advice and Consent of the Lords Spiritual and Temporal, and Commons in this present Parliament assembled*, and by the Authority of the same, as follows; that is to say, Transfer of the Government of India to Her Majesty [emphasis added].

The reference to 'Lords Spiritual' precedes Temporal and Commons; the Lords Spiritual, of course, being the Bishops of the Church of England, numbering 26 since the early 19th century, with the Archbishops of Canterbury and York holding a higher rank than the other Bishops. Critically, the Christian divide between the spiritual and temporal or secular, which I have discussed extensively in the earlier chapters, is expressly captured in the very language of the Charter Act and the Government of India Acts. There was certainly no attempt on the part of the British government to conceal or skirt around its Christian identity and the foundations of its infrastructure in Christian political theology. Surely it cannot be contended that a Parliament which legally provided (*and still does*) for the presence of 26 Bishops representing Christianity was a secular Parliament. Why, then, do we attempt to hyper-secularise what was essentially a Christian establishment when statutory facts, not merely opinion, coming straight from the horse's mouth, speak for themselves? Is this not coloniality or colonial consciousness at work?

Coming to the 1858 Act, in over 40 provisions, the Act stripped the Company of all and any powers of consequence over Bharat and transferred it to the Crown of the Christian British Empire. While the issue of granting representation to Indians arose during the debates in the British Parliament relating to the 1858 Act, the Parliament decided against it on the grounds that a significant cross-section of natives were still up in arms against the British on account of the latter's barbarity in quelling the 1857 Rebellion. Following are some of the salient provisions of the 1858 Act:

> Section 01: Territories under the Government of the East India Company to Be Vested in Her Majesty and Powers to Be Exercised in Her Name